

Scavengers and recyclers

When predators feed on their prey, they often leave parts of their kill. When they have moved on, scavengers arrive to eat the food that has not been used. Scavengers eat all kinds of remains, including animals that have died through accidents or disease, and they play a key part in nature by helping to return nutrients to the soil. Large scavengers, such as hyenas and vultures, tear the remains apart. As time goes by, many smaller animals chew and burrow their way through fur, skin, and muscle, until only scattered bones are left.



Soil microlife

Soil contains enormous numbers of animals that feed on dead remains, and also on each other. Some of them—such as earthworms and burrowing centipedes—are easy to see, but many others are almost invisible to the naked eye. This springtail feeds on tiny particles of organic matter, or detritus. Most springtails are less than $\frac{1}{4}$ in (5 mm) long, but they are among the world's most abundant animals.



Crowded carcass

As soon as the air warms up after sunrise, vultures take to the skies watching for signs of food. Their eyesight is sharp, and they descend within minutes if they spot a meal. Here, a group of vultures has gathered around a lion's kill. The lappet-faced vulture, on top of the carcass, is bald, which helps to keep it clean as it feeds. It tears open the hide, allowing smaller vultures to reach inside.

Powerful lappet-faced vulture has a 10-ft (3-m) wingspan

